

Toulouse-Lautrec

As famous for his physical deformities and colourful life in Montmartre as for his elegant and provocative images, French painter, printmaker, draughtsman and illustrator Henri de Toulouse-Lautrec (1864–1901) is among the best-known Post-Impressionists. An aristocrat whose legs stopped growing after two adolescent riding accidents, he turned to painting, after being shunned by his own social class. Living among the nightclubs, cabarets and brothels of Paris, he captured the movement, colour and exuberance of this seedy side of life.

Following Japanese print designs, Lautrec's flattened colours and angled compositions revolutionized the art of the poster and created a new form of popular art. His rapid drawing skills expressed a sense of immediacy and tension, and his paintings and prints featured vivid, unexpected colours and combinations, energetic brushstrokes and delineated outlines and contours, using paint thinned with turpentine, expressing the spontaneity and spirit of the people around him, but never judging them.



Toulouse-Lautrec, *At the Moulin Rouge*, 1892-5